

NIRODH

Under CONTROL

If the country's population growth rate is down from 2.4 per cent in 1964 to 1.8 per cent in 2005, much of it is because of the made-in-India condom

SUMEEH NEER SINGH

BLOCKING BIRTH: Social workers distributing condoms at Sanjay Gandhi Transport Nagar, Delhi



■ By M.G. Radhakrishnan

When the country had its first mass-distributed condom in 1963, the only name that seemed apt was of the Indian god of love—Kamaraj. But there was one problem. It also happened to be the name of the ruling Congress president K. Kamaraj. The second hunt for a name zeroed in on Nirodh, meaning protection, which was the brainchild of an IIM student and went on to create history in the country's family planning movement.

It was the collective effort of management academics, corporate groups, international funding agencies and top advertising agencies, backed by the Union government, which brought the spectacular success of Nirodh. It led to S. Krishna Kumar, former Union minister of state for family welfare, who as district collector of Ernakulam in the early '70s led the massive Nirodh cam-

paign in Kerala, earning the nickname "Nirodh Kumar." In 1964, India's population was 470 million (second in the world now, at 1.2 billion) and with an annual addition of 12 million, it was to double in three decades. Since urgent steps were the need of the hour, the allocation for family planning in the Third Plan was quintupled to \$56 million. Assistance was sought from international agencies, and Ford Foundation, USAID and Swedish International Development Agency (SIDA) obliged. A team

from IIM-C, led by visiting MIT professor Peter King, was asked to prepare a blueprint for new ways to successfully implement family planning methods and he suggested the large-scale introduction of condoms. The team also recommended "social marketing" of condoms that went on to create history. Condoms were available in India since the 1940s but even in 1968 the total production by four

608 m
pieces a year
make HLL one
of the world's
largest producer
of condoms